4.3 The Mining Frontier

It's 1849 and you've journeyed to California to hunt for gold. You dreamed of adventure and riches, but the living and working conditions are miserable. Worst of all, you haven't found a speck of gold!

MAIN IDEA A population boom and growing lawlessness caused by the gold rush led to the demand for California statehood.

LIFE IN A MINING CAMP

When 100,000 people crowd into the same region within a short period of time, there are bound to be problems. Few of the single men who rushed west to search for gold were interested in building stable communities. A region that had been mostly rural was suddenly covered with **boomtowns**, or mining camps that grew into crowded towns overnight. These boomtowns had neither strong leadership nor government of any kind. Law enforcement could not keep up with the boomtowns of the gold rush. Thieves and swindlers often got richer than gold miners. Bored miners living far from home spent their free time gambling and fighting with each other.

As you have read, many westward moving pioneers arrived in wagon trains on overland trails. But others decided to travel by ship. Starting on the East Coast, they sailed southward around Cape Horn at the southernmost tip of South America, and then back north to California. Overland trips took from four to six months, and the Cape Horn route took about six months.

Immigrants arrived from many countries, including Chile, Mexico, and China. San Francisco's location made it particularly accessible for people crossing the Pacific Ocean. Immigrants from China were the most numerous. Many settled in California permanently, even though they had not planned on doing so initially.

As a result, these newly established communities included people who spoke different languages, had different customs, and practiced different religions. Sometimes, cultural differences led to misunderstandings or even violence. Among white Americans, prejudices against Native Americans, African Americans, and Chinese immigrants often boiled over into fights. When gold discoveries slowed down, competition for the dwindling gold became more intense. Tensions increased, and so did crime.

Women who moved to boomtowns were far outnumbered by men and faced many challenges. In addition to the hard labor typical of living in a frontier region, they also handled domestic duties for their households. To make extra money, some even took on housekeeping tasks for single men living around them. Many women discovered a liberating independence in California because they could make a good living there. In this frontier region, few laws existed to prohibit women from owning property or businesses. Women opened profitable boarding houses, taverns, and other businesses that catered to the populations of the mining camps. Others tried their luck at mining, and a few even struck gold.

STATEHOOD FOR CALIFORNIA

Many American territories waited years before achieving statehood, but not California. With its population booming and lawlessness plaguing its mining camps, California needed a strong government right away. Since it now easily met the population requirements, many people felt that it was time for California to become a state.

In 1849, territory leaders met at a convention in Monterey to draft a constitution and to make a plan to petition the federal government for statehood. California's first constitution prohibited

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San Francisco, 1848

The California gold rush transformed the small mission of San Francisco into a thriving, vibrant city. Between 1848 and 1849, its population rose from 1,000 to 25,000. By 1860, the city had more than 50,000 people. The top illustration shows the city before the gold rush. The bottom lithograph, by the French illustrator Auguste-Victor Deroy, captures the city as he saw it in 1860. How do these two illustrations show how the landscape of San Francisco changed as more people arrived?



San Francisco, 1860



slavery. However, it did not grant civil rights to all of the state's nonwhite or female populations. Like the nation's other states at this time, California's constitution granted only white men the highest level of legal rights and protections.

In September 1850, less than two years after Sutter's workers glimpsed those first specks of gold in a Sierra mountain stream, California became the 31st state. Not surprisingly, its admission as a free state heightened the crisis over slavery that was already threatening to tear the country apart.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** How did the gold rush lead to California's application for statehood?
2. **IDENTIFY MAIN IDEAS AND DETAILS** What opportunities were women able to pursue during the gold rush, and why?
3. **EVALUATE** Did the leaders at the 1849 California constitutional convention support ideas of freedom and equality? Support your response with evidence from the text.

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